

ESQC mathematics exercises

2026 edition

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Table of contents

Preface	6
I Exercise recommendations	7
Recommended exercises for the first day	8
Basic exercises recommended for beginners	8
Recommended exercises	8
Exercises for the curious	9
Recommended exercises by topic	10
Coupled-cluster theory	10
Second quantization	10
II Mathematical foundations	11
1 Sets and functions	12
1.1 Exercises: abstract sets and functions	12
1.2 Exercises: Sets in quantum chemistry	13
2 Cardinality and countability	18
2.1 Exercises	18
3 Combinatorics	20
3.1 Exercises: Factorials	20
3.2 Exercises: Binomial coefficients and Pascal's triangle	22
III Linear algebra	25
4 General vector spaces	26
4.1 Exercises	28

5	Vectors and matrices	29
5.1	Exercises	29
5.1.1	Basic vectors	29
5.1.2	More vectors and matrices	30
6	The complex numbers as a real vector space	32
6.1	Exercises	32
7	Gaussian elimination	33
7.1	Exercises	33
8	Bra-ket notation	35
8.1	Exercises	35
9	Eigenvalues and diagonalization	36
9.1	Exercises	36
9.1.1	Eigenvalue decomposition	36
9.1.2	Diagonalization of a matrix	38
10	Gram–Schmidt orthogonalization	40
10.1	Exercises	40
11	The singular-value decomposition	43
11.1	Exercises	44
12	Polynomial vector spaces	46
12.1	Exercises	46
IV	Metric spaces and topology	49
13	Metric spaces	50
13.1	Exercises	50
14	Open and closed sets in Euclidean space	52
14.1	Exercises	52
V	Calculus	53

VI	Multivariable calculus	54
15	Visualizing functions	55
15.1	Exercises	55
16	Continuity and differentiability	57
16.1	Exercises	57
16.1.1	Continuity	57
16.1.2	Differentiability	58
VII	Series and matrix functions	59
17	Matrix exponentials and commutators	60
17.1	Exercises	60
VIII	Complex numbers and complex analysis	61
18	Complex arithmetic and geometry	62
18.1	Exercises	62
18.1.1	Complex numbers	62
18.1.2	Basic calculations	63
19	Subsets of the complex plane	64
19.1	Exercises	64
20	The complex exponential	65
20.1	Exercises	65
21	Complex power series	67
21.1	Exercises	67
22	Singularities and contour integrals	69
22.1	Exercises	69
22.1.1	Singularities	69
22.1.2	Line integrals	69

IX	Numerical methods	71
23	Dual numbers and automatic differentiation	72
23.1	Exercises	72
24	Newton's method	74
24.1	Exercises	74
25	Complex-step differentiation	76
25.1	Exercises	76
X	Fourier analysis	78
XI	Ordinary differential equations	79
XII	Partial differential equations	80
XIII	Optimization	81

Preface

This is a collection of mathematics exercises for the European Summerschool in Quantum Chemistry (ESQC).

Part I

Exercise recommendations

Recommended exercises for the first day

This chapter contains recommended exercises for the mathematics tutorial on the first day of the school. These recommended exercises are considered especially useful.

We provide also a list of recommended exercises for the ‘beginners’. If you feel that you need training in the *absolute basics* of the mathematics used in quantum chemistry, we recommend that you start here.

In the next chapter, we provide lists of recommended exercises for each quantum chemistry topic taught at the school.

Basic exercises recommended for beginners

- Exercise [1.1](#)
- Exercise [1.10](#)
- Exercise [3.1](#)
- Exercise [3.5](#)
- Exercise [3.6](#)

Recommended exercises

- Exercise [1.2](#)
- Exercise [1.8](#)
- Exercise [1.11](#)
- Exercise [2.1](#)
- Exercise [3.2](#)
- Exercise [4.1](#)
- Exercise [5.2](#)
- Exercise [5.3](#)
- Exercise [5.6](#)

- Exercise [5.7](#)
- Exercise [7.3](#)
- Exercise [12.1](#)
- Exercise [12.2](#)
- Exercise [13.1](#)
- Exercise [15.1](#)
- Exercise [15.4](#)
- Exercise [16.1](#)
- Exercise [16.4](#)
- Exercise [18.1](#)
- Exercise [18.4](#)
- Exercise [18.6](#)
- Exercise [19.1](#)
- Exercise [22.1](#)

Exercises for the curious

- Exercise [3.4](#)
- Exercise [3.7](#)
- Exercise [3.8](#)
- Exercise [6.1](#)
- Exercise [9.1](#)
- Exercise [10.1](#)
- Exercise [11.1](#)
- Exercise [23.1](#)
- Exercise [25.1](#)

Recommended exercises by topic

This chapter contains lists of mathematics exercises grouped by each quantum chemistry topic taught at the school. These exercises can be useful as a warm-up to the proper exercises given each day.

Coupled-cluster theory

Second quantization

Part II

Mathematical foundations

1 Sets and functions

Sets and set notation appear many places in quantum chemistry. The goal of this chapter is to train you in the basic usage of sets and set notation.

1.1 Exercises: abstract sets and functions

Exercise 1.1. Write the days of the week as a set

Exercise 1.2. Write the five first natural numbers using set notation as indicated in the lecture notes

Exercise 1.3. An *ordered pair* (x, y) is a two-element “set” where the order matters. Two ordered pairs (x, y) and (u, v) are equal if and only if $x = u$ and $y = v$. From this it follows that $(x, y) = (y, x)$ if and only if $x = y$. A definition of an ordered pair as a *set* is

$$(x, y) = \{\{x\}, \{x, y\}\}.$$

Show that $(x, y) = (y, x)$ if and only if $x = y$ using the set theoretic definition.

Exercise 1.4. A nonnegative rational number p/q , $p, q \in \mathbb{N}$, $q > 0$, can be written as an ordered pair (p, q) . Write down the rational numbers $1/4$, $2/3$, 0 , $1/3$ as ordered pairs using set theory, both for the pair and for each integer. (Strictly speaking we the number itself is an *equivalence class* of such pairs, i.e., $pn/qn = p/q$, so we must identify (p, q) and (np, nq) . Ignore equivalence classes in this exercise.)

Exercise 1.5. The *cartesian product* of two sets A and B is

$$A \times B = \{(a, b) \mid a \in A, b \in B\}.$$

Write down the cartesian product of $\{\heartsuit, \diamondsuit, \spadesuit, \clubsuit\}$ and $\{1, 2, 3\}$, using the set theoretic definition for the ordered pair. You can skip spelling out the set theoretic definition of the natural numbers.

Exercise 1.6. Similar to the previous exercise, write down $\{1, 2, 3\} \times \{2, 3, 4\}$.

Exercise 1.7. A function $f : A \rightarrow B$ from one set A to another set B is a rule that assigns to every $a \in A$ precisely one $b \in B$. In terms of set theory, a function $f : A \rightarrow B$ is a subset of $A \times B$, such that

- For all $a \in A$ there exists $b \in B$ such that $(a, b) \in f$.
- For all $a \in A$ and $b, b' \in B$, if $(a, b) \in f$ and $(a, b') \in f$, then $b = b'$.

Write down the function $f : \{1, 2, 3\} \rightarrow \{1, 2, 3\}$, $f(1) = 2$, $f(2) = 3$, $f(3) = 1$, using the set theoretic definition of ordered pairs and the cartesian product.

De Morgan's laws are useful when discussing subsets A, B of a larger set X . Recall that the complement of A relative to X is $A^c = X \setminus A$. De Morgan's laws state that:

- $(A \cup B)^c = A^c \cap B^c$.
- $(A \cap B)^c = A^c \cup B^c$.

Exercise 1.8. Draw a picture, representing X as the whole sheet, A and B as overlapping shapes, e.g., circles. Label A , B , $A \cap B$, and $A \cup B$, making another drawing if necessary. Convince yourself that De Morgan's laws are correct.

Exercise 1.9. Prove De Morgan's laws mathematically. Note that the complement operation acts like negation of truth, i.e., $a \in A^c$ if and only if $a \in X$ and $a \notin A$.

1.2 Exercises: Sets in quantum chemistry

Exercise 1.10. Figure 1.1 shows the *Morse potential* - a common model potential for vibrational motion of a diatomic molecule:

$$V(r) = D_e (1 - e^{-a(r-r_e)})^2 - D_e,$$

where $D_e > 0$ is the dissociation energy, $r_e > 0$ is the equilibrium bond length, and $a > 0$ is a parameter that determines the width of the potential well. The total energy of the molecule is denoted by $E \in \mathbb{R}$. The classically allowed region for the total energy E is the set S_E of all bond lengths r such that $V(r) \leq E$:

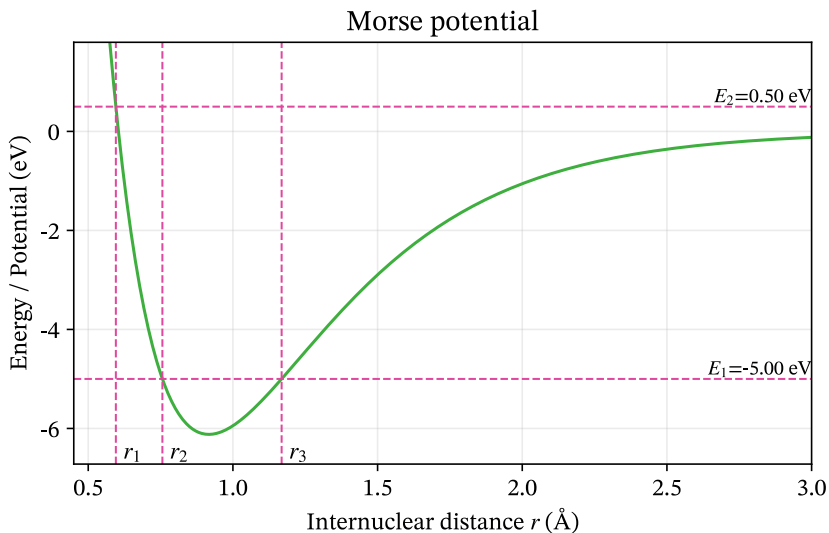


Figure 1.1: Morse potential

$$S_E = \{r \in \mathbb{R} \mid V(r) \leq E\}$$

- Explain the notation $S_E = \{r \in \mathbb{R} \mid V(r) \leq E\}$ in words. In particular, what does the vertical bar $\mid$ mean?
- Can you find a condition on E such that S_E is the empty set?
- Can you find a condition on E such that S_E is the whole real line?
- Based on the figure, which of the following statements are true?
 - $S_{E_1} = (r_2, r_3)$
 - $S_{E_1} = [r_2, r_3]$
 - $S_{E_1} = \{r_2, r_3\}$
- Based on the figure, which of the following statements are true?
 - $S_{E_2} = (r_1, +\infty)$
 - $S_{E_2} = [r_1, +\infty)$
 - $S_{E_2} = \{r_1, r_2, r_3\}$

Exercise 1.11. In this exercise, a *molecule* is informally defined only by its chemical composition: the number of atoms of each element occurring in its molecular formula. Thus, H_2 and CO are two distinct molecules, while HCOOH and CO_2H_2 represent the same molecule, since both contain one C atom, two H atoms, and two O atoms.

We ignore molecular geometry, bonding, isotopes, charge, and all questions of chemical stability. In particular, any formal combination of atoms is deemed a molecule, whether or not such a species could exist physically.

We restrict our attention to the four elements C, H, O, and N. Let M denote the set of all molecules that can be constructed from these elements. A molecule must contain at least one atom.

One useful way of describing a molecule is by the ordered quadruple

$$(n_{\text{C}}, n_{\text{H}}, n_{\text{O}}, n_{\text{N}}), \quad (1.1)$$

where each n_X is the number of atoms of element X in the molecule. For example,

$$\text{CH}_4 \longleftrightarrow (1, 4, 0, 0),$$

and

$$\text{N}_2\text{O} \longleftrightarrow (0, 0, 1, 2).$$

- Explain why Equation 1.1 uniquely determines an element of M . Give 4-5 additional examples of molecules in terms of this representation.
- Express M in terms of $\mathbb{N}_0 = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$. What is the cardinality of M ? Is it finite, countably infinite, or uncountably infinite? Justify your answer.
- Let

$$M_2 = \{m \in M \mid m \text{ contains exactly two atoms}\}.$$

Find $|M_2|$ and list all elements of M_2 .

d. Let $S \subset M$ be the set

$$S = \{m \in M \mid m \text{ contains at least one H atom}\}.$$

Describe S in terms of the quadruple representation above. Is S finite, countably infinite, or uncountably infinite? Justify your answer.

d. Describe the complement $M \setminus S$. What is its cardinality?

e. Define

$$C = \{m \in M \mid m \text{ contains at least one C atom}\}.$$

Describe the following sets both in words and in terms of the quadruple representation:

$$C \cap S, \quad C \cup S, \quad C \setminus S.$$

Determine the cardinality of each set.

f. For $n \geq 1$, define

$$M_n = \{m \in M \mid m \text{ contains exactly } n \text{ atoms}\}.$$

Thus, a molecule in M_n satisfies

$$n_{\text{C}} + n_{\text{H}} + n_{\text{O}} + n_{\text{N}} = n.$$

Show that

$$|M_n| = \binom{n+3}{3}.$$

Check that your formula agrees with your answer to part **b**.

- g. Explain why

$$M = \bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} M_n.$$

Are the sets M_n pairwise disjoint? Use this decomposition to give another argument that M is countably infinite.

- h. Show that M and S have the same cardinality. Explain why this is possible even though S is a proper subset of M .

2 Cardinality and countability

Cardinality compares sets through bijections. The exercises cover countable sets, Cantor's diagonal argument, and the cardinality of the continuum.

Recall that the *cardinality* $|S|$ of a set S is the number of elements in S . For finite sets, this is intuitive, but what about infinite sets?

One says that A and B have the same cardinality if there exists a bijection $f : A \rightarrow B$, i.e., f is one-to-one and onto. (Intuitively, you can draw lines between individual elements of A and B , only one line to/from each element. Precisely: Onto means, to every $b \in B$ there exists a $a \in A$ such that $f(a) = b$. One-to-one: $f(a) = f(a')$ implies $a = a'$.) One can think of the bijection as labelling each $b \in B$ by exactly one element $a \in A$, and that all labels from A are used up.

Let $\mathbb{N}_n = \{1, 2, \dots, n\}$. This set has cardinality n .

The set $\mathbb{N}$ has an infinite number of elements. By definition, $|\mathbb{N}| = \aleph_0$ (“aleph-nought”).

2.1 Exercises

Exercise 2.1. Show that $|\mathbb{Z}| = \aleph_0$ by explicitly constructing a bijection $f : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$.

Exercise 2.2. Show that $|\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}| = \aleph_0$. Hint: Draw a picture of $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$, and try to draw a line through all the points in this set. How does this show the existence of a bijection between $\mathbb{N}$ and $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$?

Exercise 2.3. Show that $|\mathbb{Q}| = \aleph_0$.

Exercise 2.4. Show that the interval $I = (-1, 1)$ has the same cardinality as $\mathbb{R}$. You must construct a function $f : (-1, 1) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ that is a bijection.

Exercise 2.5. In this exercise, we show that $|\mathbb{R}| > \aleph_0$. The cardinality would be $\aleph_0$ if we could write a list of the real numbers. It suffices to find a list of the numbers in $I = [0, 1[$, i.e., infinite decimal expansions $0.d_1d_2d_3\cdots$, with $d_i \in \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9\}$.

We will look for a contradiction. Consider a list $x_1, x_2, x_3, \dots$ of all real numbers in $[0, 1[$. This is essentially an infinite matrix of digits. Can you find a real number $x \in [0, 1]$ which is *not* in this list, i.e., $x \neq x_j$ for all j ? Hint: consider the diagonal of the matrix.

The cardinality of $\mathbb{R}$, “the continuum”, is written $2^{\aleph_0}$.

Exercise 2.6. Show that $|[0, 1[\times [0, 1[| = |[0, 1[|$, by constructing a one-to-one map. Hint: Use decimal expansions. Conclude that also $|\mathbb{R}^2| = |\mathbb{C}| = |\mathbb{R}|$.

3 Combinatorics

Combinatorics is the part of mathematics concerned with *counting* in a broad sense, for example counting the number of ways to arrange a set of objects or the number of combinations that can be made from a set of objects. It is a fundamental part of discrete mathematics and has applications in many areas of mathematics, computer science, chemistry, and physics.

3.1 Exercises: Factorials

The *factorial* of a non-negative integer n is defined as the product of all positive integers less than or equal to n :

$$n! = n \cdot (n - 1) \cdot (n - 2) \cdots 3 \cdot 2 \cdot 1, \quad n \geq 1.$$

It is also defined that $0! = 1$. The factorial appears in many mathematical contexts, including series expansions, and of course combinatorics. Its basic use is the following:

Factorial and counting

Given a set of n distinct objects, the number of ways to arrange them in a sequence (i.e., the number of permutations) is $n!$.

In one exercise, you will need the following approximation for large n , known as Stirling's approximation:

Stirling's approximation

For large n , the factorial $n!$ can be approximated as

$$n! \approx \sqrt{2\pi n} \left(\frac{n}{e}\right)^n.$$

In calculations, especially numerical calculations, it is often convenient to use the logarithm of the factorial. Using Stirling's approximation, we have

$$\log(n!) \approx \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi n) + n \log(n) - n.$$

Exercise 3.1. Compute the factorials $0!$, $1!$, $2!$, $3!$, $4!$, and $5!$.

Exercise 3.2. 42 people stand in a lunch line. How many different lunch line arrangements with 42 people are possible?

Exercise 3.3. Compute the number of arrangements for the following scenarios:

- A chemist has 10 different chemical samples. How many ways can the chemist arrange the samples on a shelf?
- A chemist has 10 different chemical samples. 4 of the samples are liquids, and the other 6 are solids. How many ways can the chemist arrange the samples on a shelf if all the liquids must be together?

Exercise 3.4 (Stirling's approximation). We study Stirling's approximation for the factorial.

- Use Stirling's approximation to estimate $5!$. Compare your result with the exact result

$$5! = 120.$$

- Use Stirling's approximation to estimate $10!$. Compare again with the exact number

$$10! = 3\,628\,800.$$

- The relative error of an approximation A to an exact value x is

$$\frac{|A - x|}{x}.$$

Calculate the relative error of Stirling's approximation for $5!$ and $10!$. For which value of n is the approximation better?

- d. Use Stirling's approximation to estimate $50!$. The exact value is approximately

$$50! \approx 3.041 \times 10^{64}.$$

- e. Based on your results above, what happens to the accuracy of Stirling's approximation as n increases?

3.2 Exercises: Binomial coefficients and Pascal's triangle

The *binomial coefficient* $\binom{n}{k}$ is defined as the number of ways to choose k elements from a set of n elements, without regard to the order of selection. It is given by the formula:

$$\binom{n}{k} = \frac{n!}{k!(n-k)!},$$

Pascal's triangle is a triangular array of numbers where each number is the sum of the two numbers directly above it:

$$1 \tag{3.1}$$

$$1 \quad 1 \tag{3.2}$$

$$1 \quad 2 \quad 1 \tag{3.3}$$

$$1 \quad 3 \quad 3 \quad 1 \tag{3.4}$$

$$1 \quad 4 \quad 6 \quad 4 \quad 1 \tag{3.5}$$

$$\vdots \tag{3.6}$$

Fact: The n -th row of Pascal's triangle contains the binomial coefficients $\binom{n}{0}, \binom{n}{1}, \dots, \binom{n}{n}$.

Exercise 3.5.

- Compute the binomial coefficients $\binom{5}{2}$, $\binom{6}{3}$, and $\binom{7}{4}$.
- In Norwegian Lotto, 7 numbers are drawn from a set of 34 numbers. How many different combinations of 7 numbers can be drawn?

Exercise 3.6. Compute the first 6 rows of Pascal's triangle. Verify that the numbers in the n -th row correspond to the binomial coefficients $\binom{n}{0}, \binom{n}{1}, \dots, \binom{n}{n}$.

Exercise 3.7 (Pascal's identity). The binomial coefficients satisfy **Pascal's identity**,

$$\binom{n}{k} = \binom{n-1}{k-1} + \binom{n-1}{k}.$$

- Explain why this relation is equivalent to the construction of Pascal's triangle, where each number is the sum of the two numbers directly above it.
- Write each binomial coefficient on the right-hand side in terms of factorials.
- Put the two terms over a common denominator and simplify the expression.
- Show that the resulting expression is

$$\frac{n!}{k!(n-k)!},$$

and hence prove Pascal's identity.

- Give a combinatorial explanation of Pascal's identity. *Hint:* Consider choosing k objects from a set of n objects. Pick one particular object and separate the choices into two cases: those that contain this object and those that do not.

Exercise 3.8. Write a computer program to generate the first 2^n rows of Pascal's triangle, where $n = 1, 2, \dots$. Create a $2^n \times 2^n$ lower triangular matrix T , where $T_{k,n} = 0$ if $\binom{n}{k}$ is even, and $T_{k,n} = 1$ if the coefficient is odd, for $k \leq n$ (indexing from zero). Visualize the matrix. What pattern do you observe? This pattern is known as the Sierpinski triangle.

If you use Python and sympy, you can generate binomial factors with the function `sympy.binomial(n, k)`. Check for parity using the modulo operator `%`. For example, `sympy.binomial(n, k) % 2` will return 0 for even numbers and 1 for odd numbers.

Part III

Linear algebra

4 General vector spaces

A vector space needs vector addition and scalar multiplication, but it need not resemble Euclidean coordinate space.

You may be very familiar with Euclidean space $\mathbb{R}^n$ as a vector space, and quite used to the notion that we have an inner product and a corresponding distance measure on this space. However, linear spaces are much more general. A general vector space does not have an inner product or a norm, just a “linear structure”: Consider for example a general vector space over $\mathbb{R}$: An abstract set V with operations such that one can *add vectors*,

$$z = x + y \in V,$$

and *multiply vectors by constants* $c \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$z = cx \in V$$

where $c \in \mathbb{R}$. The full set of axioms is as follows:

Definition: Vector space. A *vector space over the field* $\mathbb{F}$ is a set V together with a binary *vector addition* $+$: $V \times V \rightarrow V$ and *scalar multiplication* $\cdot$: $\mathbb{F} \times V \rightarrow V$ such that, for all $x, y, z \in V$ and all $\alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{F}$, the following axioms are true:

1. There exists a $0 \in V$ such that $0 + x = x$ for all $x \in V$
2. $x + (y + z) = (x + y) + z$
3. $x + y = y + x$
4. There exists x' such that $x + x' = 0$
5. $(\alpha\beta) \cdot x = \alpha \cdot (\beta \cdot x)$
6. $1 \cdot x = x$
7. $(\alpha + \beta) \cdot x = \alpha \cdot x + \beta \cdot x$
8. $\alpha \cdot (x + y) = \alpha \cdot x + \alpha \cdot y$

In this exercise, we will train our ability to think abstractly, and also try to get acquainted with general vector spaces.

Example: Somerset Apple Cake. Ingredients:

- 170 g butter
- 170 g light brown sugar
- 3 eggs
- 1 tablespoon liquid honey
- 1.5 teaspoons cinnamon
- 0.5 teaspoon cloves
- 0.5 teaspoon nutmeg
- 1 teaspoon baking powder
- 240 g wheat flour
- 700 g apples, diced
- 100 ml apple cider, apple juice, or milk
- 100 g light sultana raisins (optional)

Instructions:

- Cream the room-temperature butter with the sugar until light and fluffy.
- Beat in the eggs and honey.
- Sift the flour, baking powder, and spices. Add them to the mixture and stir until the batter is smooth and lump-free.
- Stir in the milk or apple cider (and the raisins, if you choose to use them; they can be soaked in cider for a couple of hours beforehand, if desired).
- Finally, fold the apple pieces into the batter.
- Pour the batter into a greased round tin with parchment paper at the bottom, or use a deep, round ovenproof dish (24 cm in diameter).

- Bake the cake in the middle of the oven at 160°C for 1.5 hours (check with a cake tester to ensure it's fully baked).
- Serve warm or cold with a dollop of whipped cream, clotted cream, vanilla ice cream, or whatever you like.

4.1 Exercises

Exercise 4.1.

1. Consider viewing the set L of cake recipe ingredient lists as a vector space. Thus, the components of L are various ingredients and their amounts. What is the dimension of this space? What are the challenges encountered?
2. How would you handle recipe lists with different units, such as pints and liters?
3. Consider the vector space L as a vector space of functions on the form $f : S \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, where S is a set. Which set would S be?
4. Define addition of two recipe ingredient lists. Does the sum define a new cake recipe? What is missing?
5. Consider the scaling of a recipe list to produce a new ingredient list. What are the units of the scaling factor?
6. Not every element in the constructed vector space is a valid recipe list. Which lists must be discarded?
7. Let us turn to the recipe steps. At least some of the steps can be interpreted as *linear operators* on the space of ingredients. For example, creaming butter and sugar transforms these two ingredients to an ingredient named “creamed butter and sugar”. Can all steps be treated as linear transformations?

5 Vectors and matrices

These exercises connect bases and vector decomposition with matrix multiplication and linear systems.

5.1 Exercises

5.1.1 Basic vectors

Exercise 5.1. We work in the space $V = \mathbb{R}^2$, plane vectors. We define two vectors,

$$\mathbf{b}_1 = [1, 2]^T, \quad \mathbf{b}_2 = [-1, 1]^T.$$

The superscript T denotes the transpose, so these are column vectors. Show by elementary means that the two vectors are linearly independent. Why do they form a basis for V ? Make a 2D drawing or plot of them as arrows from the origin.

Exercise 5.2. Let $\mathbf{v} = [2, 2]^T$. Using Gaussian elimination, compute the coefficients x_1 and x_2 such that

$$\mathbf{v} = x_1 \mathbf{b}_1 + x_2 \mathbf{b}_2.$$

Illustrate this decomposition in the graph from the previous point, using the parallelogram rule: The sum of two vectors is obtained by placing the origin of one at the end of the second, or vice versa.

Exercise 5.3. A person walks from home. First, they walk to the subway station. This is 1 km north and 500 m east as the crow flies. The subway takes the person to the city centre, which 3 km east and 2 km south of the subway station, as the crow flies. The person then walks 200 m south and 400 m west to their office.

What are the coordinates of the office, relative to the person's home?

What is the distance to home, as the crow flies?

Exercise 5.4. A boat is sailing on the ocean, at a constant speed 20 km/h relative to the water surface, in the northeast direction. However, the water surface is moving too, at a constant velocity. After two hours, the boat is located 20 km north and 10 km east of the starting point. What is the speed and direction of ocean drift?

Exercise 5.5. (Robert Beezer) A three-digit number has two properties. The tens-digit and the ones-digit add up to 5. If the number is written with the digits in the reverse order, and then subtracted from the original number, the result is 792. Use a system of equations to find all of the three-digit numbers with these properties.

5.1.2 More vectors and matrices

These exercises are to get practice with computing matrix-matrix products, and to get an intuitive feel for them.

Exercise 5.6. Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 0 & -2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 7 & -1 & 0 \\ 8 & 1 & -1 \end{bmatrix}, \quad C = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & -1 \\ 5 & 7 \\ 0 & 7 \end{bmatrix}$$

Which matrix products between pairs of these matrices are defined? Compute the products.

Exercise 5.7. Let A be the $n \times n$ matrix defined by $A_{i,i+1} = i^2$ for $1 \leq i < n$, and zero otherwise. Compute the action of A and A^T on the standard basis for $\mathbb{R}^n$. Compute the action of A and A^T on an arbitrary vector $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$.

Exercise 5.8. Let $A \in M(n, m, \mathbb{F})$, $B \in M(m, o, \mathbb{F})$. Write B in terms of column vectors, $B = [\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_o]$. Prove that

$$AB = [A\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, A\mathbf{b}_o],$$

i.e., A acts on each individual column of B . Similarly, show that, if we write A in terms of its *row vectors*,

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{a}_1^T \\ \mathbf{a}_2^T \\ \vdots \\ \mathbf{a}_n^T \end{bmatrix},$$

then

$$AB = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{a}_1^T B \\ \mathbf{a}_2^T B \\ \dots \\ \mathbf{a}_n^T B \end{bmatrix}.$$

Exercise 5.9. Show that each column of $C = AB$ is a linear combination of the columns of A with coefficients determined by B ,

$$\mathbf{c}_i = \sum_j \mathbf{a}_j B_{ji}.$$

Show a similar result for the rows of C .

6 The complex numbers as a real vector space

Identifying $x + iy$ with (x, y) turns the complex plane into a two-dimensional real vector space.

The geometrical interpretation of the $\mathbb{C}$ as the plane $\mathbb{R}^2$ indicates that $\mathbb{C}$ can be viewed as a two-dimensional real vector space. Indeed, addition and multiplication with *real* scalars are compatible with the axioms for Euclidean space $\mathbb{R}^2$.

6.1 Exercises

Exercise 6.1.

1. Show that $\mathbb{C}$ regarded can be regarded as the Euclidean plane: Check axioms for Euclidean space and check that vector addition and multiplication with real scalars are the same in the two spaces. Check also that the Euclidean norm is the modulus of the complex number. What are the complex numbers that correspond to the standard basis in $\mathbb{R}^2$? Conclude that $\mathbb{C}$ can be regarded as a *real* Euclidean vector space of dimension 2.
2. Show that multiplication with a *complex* number z is a linear operator on $\mathbb{R}^2$, and find its matrix in the standard basis. What is the matrix of multiplication with i ?
3. Show that multiplication with a complex number of modulus 1 is a rotation in $\mathbb{R}^2$.
4. Show that the map $z \mapsto \bar{z}$ is a linear transformation in $\mathbb{R}^2$. What kind of linear transformation is this? Is it a linear transformation in $\mathbb{C}$?

7 Gaussian elimination

Elementary row operations solve linear systems, compute inverses, and expose the rank and consistency of a system.

7.1 Exercises

Exercise 7.1. Compute the overlap matrix S of the basis defined in the vectors and matrices chapter. Use Gaussian elimination to compute S^{-1} .

Exercise 7.2. Write down the dual basis of $B = \{\mathbf{b}_1, \mathbf{b}_2\}$.

Exercise 7.3. (Robert Beezer) Consider the following system of equations:

$$\begin{aligned}2x_1 - 3x_2 + x_3 + 7x_4 &= 14 \\2x_1 + 8x_2 - 4x_3 + 5x_4 &= -1 \\x_1 + 3x_2 - 3x_3 &= 4 \\-5x_1 + 2x_2 + 3x_3 + 4x_4 &= -19\end{aligned}$$

Use Gaussian elimination to find all possible solutions. Write the solution set using set notation.

Exercise 7.4. (Robert Beezer) Find all possible solutions of the linear system

$$\begin{aligned}3x_1 + 4x_2 - x_3 + 2x_4 &= 6 \\x_1 - 2x_2 + 3x_3 + x_4 &= 2 \\10x_2 - 10x_3 - x_4 &= 1\end{aligned}$$

Write down the solution set using set notation.

Exercise 7.5. (Robert Beezer) Find all possible solutions of the linear system

$$\begin{aligned}2x_1 + 4x_2 + 5x_3 + 7x_4 &= -26 \\x_1 + 2x_2 + x_3 - x_4 &= -4 \\-2x_1 - 4x_2 + x_3 + 11x_4 &= -10\end{aligned}$$

Write down the solution set using set notation.

Exercise 7.6. Let $\mathbf{b}_i, i = 1, 2, \dots, n$ be a basis for $\mathbb{R}^n$. Let

$$B = [\mathbf{b}_1, \mathbf{b}_2, \dots, \mathbf{b}_n]$$

be the *basis matrix*, whose columns are precisely the $\mathbf{b}_i$. Explain that if $\mathbf{y} = x_1\mathbf{b}_1 + \dots + x_n\mathbf{b}_n$, then

$$B\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y}.$$

Solve for $\mathbf{x}$ using B in symbols.

Exercise 7.7. Let n linearly independent vectors $B = \{\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_n\}$ of $\mathbb{F}^n$ be given. Write down a formula for the dual basis in terms of the overlap matrix.

8 Bra-ket notation

Bra-ket notation represents vectors, inner products, operators, and basis expansions in a form used throughout quantum mechanics.

8.1 Exercises

Exercise 8.1. Let $B = \{b_1, b_2, \dots, b_n\}$ be a basis for a finite-dimensional Hilbert space V , and let $\{|i\rangle\}$ be the standard basis for $\mathbb{C}^n$. Consider the operator

$$\hat{B} = \sum_{i=1}^n |b_i\rangle \langle i|.$$

What are the domain and range of $\hat{B}$?

Exercise 8.2. Let $|x\rangle \in \mathbb{C}^n$, and consider

$$|\psi\rangle = \hat{B}|x\rangle.$$

Can you interpret this expression in terms of bases and expansion coefficients?

Exercise 8.3. Show that

$$\hat{S} = \sum_{i,j} |i\rangle \langle b_i | b_j \rangle \langle j|.$$

This is the overlap matrix expressed as an operator. Find an expression for the basis coefficients x_i in terms of the basis alone.

9 Eigenvalues and diagonalization

These exercises develop the spectral theorem and apply determinants to finite-dimensional eigenvalue problems.

9.1 Exercises

9.1.1 Eigenvalue decomposition

Of great importance to quantum chemistry is the time-independent Schrödinger equation: Given the Hamiltonian operator $\hat{H}$, which is usually Hermitian, find a nonzero $|\psi\rangle$, called an eigenvector, and a real number E , called an eigenvalue, such that

$$\hat{H}|\psi\rangle = E|\psi\rangle.$$

Choosing a particular orthonormal basis $\{|\phi_i\rangle\}$ for Hilbert space, a matrix eigenvalue problem arises,

$$A\mathbf{u} = E\mathbf{u}, \quad u_i = \langle\phi_i|\psi\rangle, \quad A_{ij} = \langle\phi_i|\hat{H}|\phi_j\rangle.$$

We prove the spectral theorem for normal operators over finite dimensional Hilbert spaces. The spectral theorem states that one can actually find a *basis* of eigenvectors for normal operators. The normal operators include the Hermitian operators.

In this section, we let $M(n) = M(n, n, \mathbb{C}) = \mathbb{C}^{n \times n}$ be the set of complex square matrices of dimension n .

Two matrices A and B are said to be *similar* if there is an invertible matrix U such that $A = UBU^{-1}$. If U is unitary, then A and B are *unitarily similar*. (U is unitary if and only if $U^H = U^{-1}$.)

Exercise 9.1.

1. What does it mean that $A \in M(n)$ is normal?
2. Prove that a diagonal matrix $D \in M(n)$ is normal. (A matrix A is diagonal if and only if $A_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i \neq j$.)
3. Prove that U is unitary if and only if its columns are orthonormal.
4. Prove that if A is normal and B is unitarily similar to A , then B is normal.
5. Prove that if A is unitarily equivalent to a diagonal matrix, then A is normal.

The next part requires *Schur's Lemma*:

Lemma: Schur's Lemma. Let $A \in M(n)$. Then A is unitarily equivalent to an upper triangular matrix. (R is upper triangular if $R_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i > j$.)

The proof of Schur's Lemma can be found in, e.g., Fraleigh and Beauregard.

1. Prove that every normal matrix A is unitarily equivalent to a normal upper-triangular matrix B . (Use Schur's Lemma and exercise that normality is preserved by unitary similarity.)
2. Prove that a normal upper triangular matrix B must be diagonal. Hint: Let $C = B^H B = B B^H$, and compute C_{11} to show that $B_{1j} = 0$ if $j > 1$. Continue to C_{22} , and all the way up to C_{nn} .

We have now proved:

Theorem: Spectral theorem for normal matrices. Suppose $A \in M(n)$ is normal, i.e., $AA^H = A^H A$. Then there is a unitary matrix $U \in M(n)$ and a diagonal matrix $D \in M(n)$ such that

$$A = UDU^H. \quad \text{spectral decomposition}$$

1. Let $\mathbf{u}_i = U_{:,i}$ be the i th column for U . Explain why these vectors form a basis for $\mathbb{C}^n$.
2. Show that

$$A = \sum_{i=1}^n d_i \mathbf{u}_i \mathbf{u}_i^H, \quad d_i = D_{ii}. \quad \text{spectral decomposition}$$

Write this formula also using bra-ket notation.

3. What does A do with the vector $\mathbf{u}_k$ for some k ? What does A do to a linear combination of the basis vectors?

A special kind of normal matrix is a Hermitian matrix, for which

$$A^H = A.$$

1. Show that a Hermitian matrix is unitarily equivalent to a diagonal matrix with *real* numbers on the diagonal, i.e., $A = UDU^H$ with $D_{ii} \in \mathbb{R}$.

9.1.2 Diagonalization of a matrix

A matrix A has an eigenvalue E if and only if there is a nonzero solution to the linear system

$$(A - EI)\mathbf{x} = 0.$$

Thus, the matrix $A - EI$ must be singular, i.e., not invertible. The eigenvector $\mathbf{x}$ is then a vector in the null space of this matrix.

A sufficient and necessary criterion for invertibility of a matrix B is that the *determinant* is nonzero. The definition of the determinant can be stated as follows:

Definition: Determinant. Let $A \in M(n)$. The determinant, written $\det(A) \in \mathbb{C}$ is defined by

$$\det(A) = \sum_{p \in S_n} (-1)^{|p|} A_{1,p(1)} A_{2,p(2)} \cdots A_{n,p(n)}.$$

Here, S_N is the set of *permutations* of the numbers $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$. A permutation is by definition any bijective map.

Each permutation $p \in S_n$ is a rearrangement is thus completely specified by the new order of the numbers $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$, i.e., $(p(1), p(2), \dots, p(n))$. For example, $(1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6) \in S_6$ is the *identity permutation* that leaves any number alone. The permutation $(3, 2, 1, 4, 6, 5)$ makes 1 and 3 switch place, and 5 and 6.

Any permutation can be written as a product (composition) of *transpositions*, i.e., exchanges of exactly two elements. Thus, $(3, 1, 2) = (1, 2)(2, 3)$. Here, the two-element notation indicates which elements are switched. Every decomposition of a given permutation uses either an even number of transpositions or an odd number, denoted $|p|$ modulo 2. The *sign* of a permutation p is $(-1)^{|p|}$.

There are $n!$ unique permutations of an n -element set.

Exercise 9.2. Write out the set of permutations S_1, S_2 and S_3 .

Exercise 9.3. Compute the sign of the permutations of the previous exercise.

Exercise 9.4. Compute explicit expressions for the determinants of matrices of dimension 1, 2, and 3.

Exercise 9.5. (Extra.) In Python, the module `itertools` contains an iterator class `permutations` that allow efficient looping over permutations. Can you write a function that computes the sign of a permutation? Use the internet for efficiency.

Exercise 9.6. Compute explicit expressions for the determinants of matrices of dimension up to 3. By equating the determinant of $A - EI$ with zero, a polynomial equation in E is obtained. Find the solutions in the case $n = 2$.

Exercise 9.7. Consider the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} -1 & z \\ z & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

For which $z \in \mathbb{C}$ is A Hermitian? Normal? Compute the eigenvalues as function of z . Also find the eigenvectors.

Exercise 9.8. For which values of z does there exist a basis of eigenvectors?

10 Gram–Schmidt orthogonalization

Orthogonal projection leads to the Gram–Schmidt construction and the QR factorization of a full-rank matrix.

Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{F}$ with $\dim(V) = n < +\infty$. Recall that every finite-dimensional vector space has a basis. In the lecture notes, it is claimed that every finite dimensional Hilbert space has a basis of orthonormal vectors! Recall, that in an orthonormal basis, computations are usually much simpler than in nonorthogonal bases.

In this exercise, we show that any set of linearly independent vectors can be orthonormalized. We work in the space $\mathbb{F}^n$ for simplicity. That is, let $B = [\mathbf{b}_1, \dots, \mathbf{b}_m] \subset \mathbb{F}^n$ be a set of $m \leq n$ linearly independent vectors, spanning a subspace $V = \text{span}(B)$. We denote the vector set by its basis matrix B . Equivalently, B is an arbitrary matrix in $M(n, m, \mathbb{F})$ of full rank m , and the vectors $\mathbf{b}_i$ are the columns of B .

We will find a set of orthonormal vectors $U = [\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_m]$, again denoted by a matrix in $M(n, m, \mathbb{F})$, such that $\text{span}(B) = \text{span}(U)$. That is, the two sets of vectors are bases for the *same* subspace, but one of them is an orthonormal basis.

We first define the notion of orthogonal projection onto the span of a single vector: Let $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{F}^n$ be nonzero, $Y = \text{span}(\mathbf{y})$, and let $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{F}^n$.

10.1 Exercises

Exercise 10.1.

1. Show that the vector $\mathbf{x}_Y$ given by

$$\mathbf{x}_Y = \mathbf{y} \frac{\langle \mathbf{y}, \mathbf{x} \rangle}{\langle \mathbf{y}, \mathbf{y} \rangle}$$

is the *unique* vector in Y , such that

$$\forall \mathbf{y}' \in Y, \quad \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_Y\| \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}'\|.$$

Hint: Find a function $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ which you can study, by using the definition of $Y = \text{span}(\mathbf{y})$.

2. Show that

$$\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x}_Y + \mathbf{x}_{Y^\perp},$$

where

$$\langle \mathbf{x}_{Y^\perp} | \mathbf{x}_Y \rangle = 0.$$

Illustrate with a picture of the situation in $\mathbb{R}^2$.

The vector $\mathbf{x}_Y$ is called the *orthogonal projection of $\mathbf{x}$ onto Y or $\mathbf{y}$* .

1. Explain that the orthogonal projection is given by acting with an operator,

$$\mathbf{x}_Y = P_Y \mathbf{x}, \quad P_Y = \mathbf{y} \langle \mathbf{y}, \mathbf{y} \rangle^{-1} \mathbf{y}^H.$$

The operator P_Y is called the *orthogonal projection operator onto $Y = \text{span}(\mathbf{y})$* .

1. Show that $P^2 = P$ and that $P^\dagger = P$.

The Gram–Schmidt orthogonalization proceeds recursively:

1. $\mathbf{u}_1 = \mathbf{b}_1 \langle \mathbf{b}_1, \mathbf{b}_1 \rangle^{-1/2}$ (normalization)
2. $\mathbf{u}'_2 = \mathbf{b}_2 - P_{\mathbf{u}_1} \mathbf{b}_2$ (removal of projection), and $\mathbf{u}_2 = \mathbf{u}'_2 \langle \mathbf{u}'_2, \mathbf{u}'_2 \rangle^{-1/2}$ (normalization)
3. $\mathbf{u}'_3 = \mathbf{b}_3 - P_{\mathbf{u}_1} \mathbf{b}_3 - P_{\mathbf{u}_2} \mathbf{b}_3$ (removal of projection), and $\mathbf{u}_3 = \mathbf{u}'_3 \langle \mathbf{u}'_3, \mathbf{u}'_3 \rangle^{-1/2}$ (normalization)
4. Continue recursively.
5. $\mathbf{u}'_m = \mathbf{b}_m - \sum_{i=1}^{m-1} P_{\mathbf{u}_i} \mathbf{b}_m$ (removal of projection), and $\mathbf{u}_m = \mathbf{u}'_m \langle \mathbf{u}'_m, \mathbf{u}'_m \rangle^{-1/2}$ (normalization)

We see that each $\mathbf{u}_i$ is given by projecting away from $\mathbf{b}_i$ the components of all the *previously generated* $\mathbf{u}_j$, $j < i$.

1. Show that all the generated vectors $\mathbf{u}_i$ are orthonormal.
2. Show that a set of orthonormal vectors are linearly independent.

3. Show that the span of the first k original vectors is the same as the span of the first k generated vectors. Show that

$$B = UR,$$

where $R \in M(m, m, \mathbb{F})$ is *upper triangular*, i.e., $R_{ij} = 0$ whenever $i > j$. This is called the QR decomposition of the operator B . (The “Q” is just our U .)

4. We have shown the existence of the QR decomposition when B had full rank. Can you show the existence of the decomposition when B does *not* have full rank? It always exists. Hint: What happens when B does not have full rank?

We now turn to a computational exercise:

1. Write a Python function to compute the QR decomposition of a matrix with full rank. In SciPy, the function `scipy.linalg.qr` is an advanced implementation with pivoting. To compare with your implementation, use the call

```
Q,R = qr(A,mode='economic',pivoting=False)
```

With `pivoting=False`, the function computes essentially the same as our presented algorithm. (Turning on pivoting stabilizes the algorithm, rearranging the vectors before orthogonalizing.)

2. Let $n \geq m > 0$ be integers, and define the matrix $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times m}$ by

$$A_{ij} = \left(\frac{i-1}{n-1} \right)^{j-1}.$$

This is the matrix of the m first monomials x^{j-1} evaluated at an equidistant grid of n points in the interval $[0, 1]$. Test your QR implementation on A for various n, m , say $m = 10$ and $m = 200$. In particular, compute the difference between your factorization and A , and compare also with the NumPy implementation.

11 The singular-value decomposition

The singular-value decomposition gives orthogonal matrix expansions and low-rank approximations, including image compression.

The SVD is a powerful linear algebra tool. In quantum chemistry it is used to compress electron-repulsion integrals, for example.

In this small exercise, we demonstrate its power applied to *image compression*. For this exercise, a good grayscale image is handy. You can find a nice picture of a parrot in Figure 11.1.

Recall first the *Hilbert–Schmidt* inner product on the set $M(n, m, \mathbb{F})$ of matrices:

$$\langle X, Y \rangle_{\text{HS}} = \text{Tr}(X^H Y)$$

The *trace* $\text{Tr}(A)$ is the sum of the diagonal elements of A .

Recall also the SVD: For $A \in M(n, m, \mathbb{F})$ and $k = \min(n, m)$, there are unitary matrices $U \in M(n)$ and $V \in M(m)$ and singular values $\sigma_1 \geq \sigma_2 \geq \dots \geq \sigma_k \geq 0$ such that

$$A = U \Sigma V^H = \sum_{i=1}^k \mathbf{u}_i \sigma_i \mathbf{v}_i^H.$$

Here $\Sigma \in M(n, m, \mathbb{R})$ has the singular values in its upper $k \times k$ diagonal block and zeros elsewhere. Removing unused columns gives the economical SVD

$$A = U_{:, :k} \Sigma_{:, :k} V_{:, :k}^H.$$



Figure 11.1: A parrot, <https://www.dropbox.com/s/8r4svs6uuhgawwt/parrot.png>

11.1 Exercises

Exercise 11.1.

1. How is the Hilbert–Schmidt inner product related to the Euclidean inner product and the standard Euclidean vector space?
2. Show that $\text{Tr}(ABC) = \text{Tr}(CAB)$ (cyclic invariance).
3. Let $\mathbf{u}_i$ and $\mathbf{v}_i$ be the left and right singular vectors of a matrix A . Show that the matrices $X^{ij} = \mathbf{u}_i \mathbf{v}_j^H$ form an orthonormal set in the Hilbert–Schmidt inner product.
4. Conclude that the SVD is an expansion of a matrix in an orthonormal basis.

The *truncated* SVD

$$A^{(m)} = \sum_{i=1}^m \mathbf{u}_i \sigma_i \mathbf{v}_i^H$$

is the best approximation to A of rank at most m in the Hilbert–Schmidt norm:

$$A^{(m)} = \arg \min_{\text{rank}(B) \leq m} \|B - A\|_{\text{HS}}.$$

1. Write a Python program/notebook that reads an image file and converts it to a matrix $A \in M(n, m, \mathbb{R})$. The module `imageio` can be useful.
2. Continue writing the program, so it computes the truncated and full SVD of A . You can use, say, `scipy.linalg.svd` to find the full SVD.
3. Plot the singular values. Discuss.
4. Show that the error in the Hilbert–Schmidt norm is

$$\|A^{(m)} - A\|_{\text{HS}} = \sqrt{\sum_{i=m+1}^k \sigma_i^2}.$$

5. Make visualizations of the truncated SVD of the image A , with various m . Compute the relative error $\|A^{(m)} - A\|_{\text{HS}} / \|A\|_{\text{HS}}$ for each m you consider. Discuss the image quality.

12 Polynomial vector spaces

Polynomials form finite-dimensional vector spaces on which differentiation, multiplication, and changes of basis act as linear maps.

In this exercise, we study a vector space that is not $\mathbb{F}^n$. We start out without an inner product, but supply this later.

Recall that a polynomial of degree n over $\mathbb{F}$ has the form

$$p(x) = a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + \cdots + a_nx^n,$$

with $a_i \in \mathbb{F}$ and $a_n \neq 0$.

12.1 Exercises

Exercise 12.1. Let P_n be the set of all polynomials of degree less than or equal to n . Show that P_n is a vector space of dimension $n + 1$ over $\mathbb{C}$.

Exercise 12.2. Let $D : P_n \rightarrow P_n$ be the differentiation operator, i.e.,

$$(Dp)(x) = p'(x).$$

Show that D is indeed a linear operator.

Exercise 12.3. Does there exist an inverse of D ?

Exercise 12.4. Let $B = \{1, x, x^2, \dots, x^n\}$ be the basis of *monomials*. Using bra-ket notation, we write the basis operator as

$$\hat{B} = \sum_{i=1}^{n+1} |x^{i-1}\rangle \langle i|,$$

where $|i\rangle$ is a standard basis vector for $\mathbb{F}^{n+1}$. Compute the matrix of D relative to this basis. (Note carefully that we do not have an inner product defined.) That is, find a matrix T such that

$$D\hat{B} = \hat{B}T.$$

We now restrict our attention to the interval $x \in [-1, 1]$. That is,

$$V_n = \{p : [-1, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{C} \mid p \text{ a polynomial of } \deg \leq n\}.$$

The above subexercises did not depend on the domain of the polynomial.

We define an inner product on V ,

$$\langle p|q \rangle := \int_{-1}^1 \overline{p(x)}q(x) dx.$$

We will now define the *Legendre polynomials*.

Exercise 12.5. Show that $\langle \cdot | \cdot \rangle$ is indeed an inner product by checking the axioms.

Exercise 12.6. Compute the overlap matrix S of the monomial basis. Is the basis orthonormal?

Exercise 12.7. Formulate the Gram–Schmidt procedure using the bra-ket notation. Explain how the procedure generates an upper triangular matrix R such that

$$\hat{B} = \hat{U}R,$$

where $\hat{U}$ is the basis matrix of the orthonormal set of vectors.

Exercise 12.8. Use the Gram–Schmidt decomposition by hand to compute the first three *normalized Legendre polynomials* $|\hat{P}_i\rangle$, $i = 0, 1, 2$, defined using the Gram–Schmidt orthogonalization of $\{1, x, x^2\}$.

The Legendre polynomials are orthogonal polynomials $P_i : [-1, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ obtained from the monomials by Gram–Schmidt orthogonalization and normalized by $P_i(1) = 1$. They are orthogonal but not normalized. The endpoint normalization gives

$$\int_{-1}^1 P_i(x)P_j(x) dx = \frac{2}{2i+1} \delta_{ij}.$$

With $P_0(x) = 1$ and $P_{-1} \equiv 0$, they satisfy the recurrence relation

$$(i+1)P_{i+1}(x) = (2i+1)xP_i(x) - iP_{i-1}(x).$$

From this, one can show:

$$P'_{i+1}(x) = \frac{2P_i(x)}{\|P_i\|^2} + \frac{2P_{i-2}(x)}{\|P_{i-2}\|^2} + \frac{2P_{i-4}(x)}{\|P_{i-4}\|^2} + \dots$$

Exercise 12.9. Compute the matrix of the differential operator D in the *normalized* Legendre polynomial basis, both by using matrix multiplication involving X , R , and R^{-1} , and also by using the derivative relation above. Compare the two explicitly using pen-and-paper calculations.

Exercise 12.10. Repeat the previous exercise with the operator D^2 .

Orthogonal polynomials define efficient *quadrature rules*. Consider approximating an integral by

$$\int_{-1}^1 f(x) dx \approx \sum_{i=1}^n f(x_i) w_i,$$

where the w_i are *weights* and the x_i are *nodes*. A unique choice of nodes and weights makes the rule exact for every polynomial of degree at most $2n - 1$. The nodes are the zeros of P_n , and the weights are

$$w_i = \frac{2}{(1 - x_i^2)[P_n'(x_i)]^2}.$$

The [Wikipedia page on Gauss–Legendre quadrature](#) contains more details.

The so-called Golub–Welsch algorithm is a simple algorithm based on diagonalization of a tridiagonal Hermitian matrix for computing the nodes and weights of Gaussian quadratures, see [the Wikipedia page on Gaussian quadrature](#). The interested student should check it out!

Part IV

Metric spaces and topology

13 Metric spaces

A metric measures distance through symmetry, positivity, and the triangle inequality.

A *metric* encodes the intuition behind measuring *distances* in a set M . It is a distance function $d(x, y)$, where $x, y \in M$.

The definition of a metric space is as follows:

Definition: Metric. Let M be a set. A function $d : M \times M \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is a *metric* if it satisfies the following axioms:

1. $d(x, y) = d(y, x)$
2. $d(x, y) \geq 0$, and $d(x, y) = 0$ if and only if $x = y$
3. $d(x, y) \leq d(x, z) + d(z, y)$

The pair (M, d) is a *metric space*. If M is a vector space, we say that (M, d) is a *metric vector space*.

In this exercise, we will try to understand why the axioms are as they are, i.e., what makes them encode the concept of a metric.

13.1 Exercises

Exercise 13.1.

1. Consider two persons X and Y located at x and y in a set M . They both measure the distance to the other person. What would happen if axiom a) is violated? Is this reasonable?
2. What would happen if axiom b) is violated? Is this reasonable?
3. A third person Z located at z enters the picture. Consider axiom c). What happens if this axiom is violated? Is this reasonable?

4. Let $M = \mathbb{R}^2$, and let d be Euclidean distance, “as the crow flies”. But there are other distance measures as well. Consider for example the “Manhattan distance”, given by

$$d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) = |x_1 - y_1| + |x_2 - y_2|.$$

This has a standard interpretation in terms of cities with straight streets and taxis driving on these streets. Discuss.

5. Consider a king moving on a chessboard. The king can move one step at a time, either horizontally or vertically, or diagonally. Consider the *minimum number of steps* the king has to move in order to get from one point to another. See Figure 13.1 for an illustration. The metric is

$$d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) = \max(|x_1 - y_1|, |x_2 - y_2|).$$

This is also called the “maximum metric”. Can you verify the metric axioms? How does the maximum metric compare to the Manhattan metric?

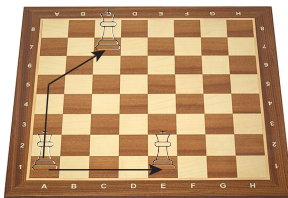


Figure 13.1: Illustration of “chessboard metric”: The king can move horizontally, vertically, and diagonally. The chessboard metric is the smallest number of steps the king must move in order to get from one point to another. Here, the king starts at A1, and two paths are shown: The optimal path to C7, and the optimal path to E1. Note that the king will move diagonally as much as he can, because he travels “faster” that way!

14 Open and closed sets in Euclidean space

Open balls define interior points, open sets, closed sets, boundaries, and closures in Euclidean space.

14.1 Exercises

Exercise 14.1. Show that any ϵ -ball is open.

Exercise 14.2. Show that $A \cup \partial A$ is closed.

Exercise 14.3. Show that if $A \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ is closed and a sequence $\mathbf{x}_i \in A$ converges to some $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, then $\mathbf{x} \in A$. This gives an equivalent characterization of closed subsets of $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Exercise 14.4. Show that the closure of A , the smallest closed set $\bar{A}$ that contains A , is equal to $A \cup \partial A$.

Exercise 14.5. Show that

$$A = \{(x, 0) \mid x \in [-1, 1]\} \subset \mathbb{R}^2$$

is closed.

Exercise 14.6. Show that $\mathbb{Q} \subset \mathbb{R}$ is neither open nor closed. Show that the boundary of $\mathbb{Q}$ is $\mathbb{R}$. Show that the interior of $\mathbb{Q}$ is empty. What is the closure of $\mathbb{Q}$?

Exercise 14.7. Let

$$A = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 \mid 0 \leq x < 1, \quad 0 \leq y < 1\}.$$

Compute the interior of A , the boundary of A , the closure of A .

Part V

Calculus

Part VI

Multivariable calculus

15 Visualizing functions

Graphs, level sets, and vector fields provide complementary views of scalar- and vector-valued functions.

Some paths and their curves:

15.1 Exercises

Exercise 15.1. Let $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ be a path defined by

$$f(t) = [r(t) \cos(4t), r(t) \sin(4t)], \quad r(t) = \exp(-t).$$

Sketch the curve traced by the path for $0 \leq t \leq 2\pi$. You can check your sketch against, say, a Python plot.

Exercise 15.2. Let $f : (0, +\infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ be a path defined by

$$f(t) = [\ln(t), t].$$

Sketch the curve traced by the path. You can check your sketch against, say, a Python plot.

Exercise 15.3. Let $f : [0, \pi] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ be given by $f(t) = [x(t), y(t)]$, with $x(t) = 16 \sin(t)^3$ and $y(t) = 13 \cos(t) - 5 \cos(2t) - 2 \cos(3t) - \cos(4t)$. Sketch the curve. Here, it is probably easiest to use Python or a similar tool.

Level curves:

Exercise 15.4. Let $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$. Sketch the level curves $\{(x, y) \mid f(x, y) = n\}$, for $n = 1$ and $n = 2$, $n = 3$, and $n = 4$.

Exercise 15.5. Let $f(x, y) = x + y + 2$. Sketch the level curves where $f(x, y) = 0$, 2 and 4. Can you sketch the graph of f ?

Exercise 15.6. Let $f(x, y) = x^2 - y^2$. The graph is called the *hyperbolic paraboloid*, or a saddle. Sketch the graph. Sketch the level curves $\{(x, y) \mid f(x, y) = n\}$, for $n = 0$ and $n = -1, n = 1$. Make sure that you get all “pieces”.

Exercise 15.7. Write a Python program for sketching the level curves in the hyperbolic-paraboloid exercise above, but use more closely spaced constants. There are tools in Matplotlib that are handy.

Exercise 15.8. Adapt your program to draw level curves of $(x, y) \mapsto (x^2 + 3y^2)e^{1-x^2-y^2}$.

Sections and level surfaces:

Consider the hydrogen-atom eigenfunctions in atomic units. They are indexed by $n \geq 1$, $0 \leq \ell < n$, and $-\ell \leq m \leq \ell$. Their separated form is

$$\psi_{n\ell m}(r, \theta, \phi) = R_{n\ell}(r)Y_{\ell m}(\theta, \phi),$$

with

$$R_{n\ell}(r) = N_{n\ell} \rho^\ell L_{n-\ell-1}^{2\ell+1}(\rho) e^{-\rho/2}, \quad \rho = \frac{2r}{n}.$$

Here $N_{n\ell}$ is a normalization constant. Coordinate conversion uses

$$r = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2 + z^2}, \quad x = r \sin \theta \cos \phi, \quad y = r \sin \theta \sin \phi, \quad z = r \cos \theta.$$

In particular, the $1s$ and $2p_z$ functions are given by

$$\begin{aligned} \psi_{1s}(x, y, z) &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi}} e^{-r(x,y,z)}, \\ \psi_{2p_z}(x, y, z) &= \frac{1}{4\sqrt{2\pi}} z e^{-r(x,y,z)/2}, \end{aligned}$$

Exercise 15.9. Write a Python program to draw the level *surfaces* of hydrogen orbitals, $\{(x, y, z) \mid \psi(x, y, z) = c\}$. Choose interesting values of c . It can be interesting to color code surfaces of opposite positive and negative c .

Exercise 15.10. Write a program to visualize *sections* of the orbital graphs. For example, fix $y = y_{\text{const}}$ and plot $(x, z) \mapsto \psi(x, y_{\text{const}}, z)$.

16 Continuity and differentiability

Limits define continuity, while partial derivatives describe local change for functions of several variables.

16.1 Exercises

16.1.1 Continuity

Exercise 16.1. Let $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be given by

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} 1 & x > 0 \\ -1 & x \leq 0 \end{cases}$$

For which $x \in \mathbb{R}$ does the limit

$$\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} f(x + h)$$

not exist? Why?

Exercise 16.2. Show that any polynomial $p : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous, by using the theorem on properties of continuous functions.

Exercise 16.3. (Marsden and Tromba) Consider the function

$$f(x, y) = \frac{\sin(x^2 + y^2)}{x^2 + y^2}.$$

This function is defined on $\mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0, 0)\}$. Determine whether $f(x, y)$ approaches some value as $(x, y) \rightarrow (0, 0)$. What is this value?

Exercise 16.4. (Marsden and Tromba) Does $\lim_{(x,y) \rightarrow (0,0)} x^2/(x^2 + y^2)$ exist? If you want, plotting the function can help.

Exercise 16.5. (Marsden and Tromba) Prove that $\lim_{(x,y) \rightarrow (0,0)} 2x^2y/(x^2 + y^2) = 0$ using an ϵ - δ argument.

16.1.2 Differentiability

Exercise 16.6. Compute the partial derivatives of

$$f(x, y) = \frac{xy}{(x^2 + y^2)^{1/2}}.$$

Part VII

Series and matrix functions

17 Matrix exponentials and commutators

Power series define matrix exponentials. Differentiating products of exponentials produces nested commutators.

Consider the *matrix-valued function*

$$f(t) = e^{-tA} B e^{tA},$$

where A and B are square matrices. The matrix exponential is defined in terms of the Taylor series,

$$\exp(X) = \mathbf{1} + X + \frac{1}{2!}X^2 + \frac{1}{3!}X^3 + \cdots,$$

which is convergent. It is a fact that if $XY - YX = [X, Y] = 0$ (commuting matrices) then $\exp(X + Y) = \exp(X)\exp(Y)$, by the same proof as for the exponential function over a field $\mathbb{F}$.

17.1 Exercises

Exercise 17.1. Explain why we may view f as a vector-valued function

Exercise 17.2. Show that $t \mapsto e^{tA}$ is differentiable.

Exercise 17.3. Show that f is differentiable. Compute its derivatives to arbitrary order

Part VIII

Complex numbers and complex analysis

18 Complex arithmetic and geometry

Cartesian and polar forms connect complex arithmetic with plane geometry, rotations, dot products, and cross products.

18.1 Exercises

18.1.1 Complex numbers

Exercise 18.1. Let $z = x + iy \in \mathbb{C}$, and compute the real and imaginary parts of z^2 , z^3 , and z^4 , as functions of x and y .

Exercise 18.2. Compute a closed-form expression for the real and imaginary parts of z^n .

Exercise 18.3. Compute closed-form expression for z^{-1} , exhibiting the real and imaginary parts as functions of x and y . (Assuming $z \neq 0$). Try to compute closed-form expressions of z^{-2} and z^n as well.

Exercise 18.4. A complex number $z = x + iy$ can be written in polar form,

$$x = r \cos(\theta), \quad y = r \sin(\theta).$$

Write down the rule for $z^n = R \cos \phi + iR \sin \phi$ using angle θ and modulus r .

Exercise 18.5. Consider the polynomial equation $f(z) = z^3 + 1 = 0$. Find all the roots in the complex plane using polar coordinates. Sketch the roots in a coordinate system.

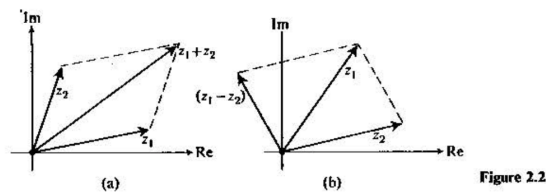


Figure 18.1: The parallelogram rule. (From Butkov.)

18.1.2 Basic calculations

Exercise 18.6. Let $z = x + iy \in \mathbb{C}$. Illustrate the addition $w = z + \bar{z}$ in a coordinate system using the parallelogram rule.

Exercise 18.7. Recall our earlier exercise, where $\mathbb{C}$ was regarded as the real vector space $\mathbb{R}^2$. Let $z_i = x_i + iy_i$, and denote the corresponding vectors in $\mathbb{R}^2$ by $\mathbf{v}_i$. Show that

$$\langle \mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2 \rangle = \Re(\bar{z}_1 z_2) = \Re(z_1 \bar{z}_2).$$

Exercise 18.8. Another product in $\mathbb{R}^2$ (and indeed $\mathbb{R}^3$) is the *cross product*:

$$\mathbf{v}_1 \times \mathbf{v}_2 = \begin{vmatrix} v_{11} & v_{12} \\ v_{21} & v_{22} \end{vmatrix},$$

the matrix determinant. Show that

$$\mathbf{v}_1 \times \mathbf{v}_2 = \Im(\bar{z}_1 z_2) = -\Im(z_1 \bar{z}_2).$$

Exercise 18.9. Show that the function $z \mapsto iz$ is a counterclockwise rotation by $\pi/2$. Find the function that performs a clockwise rotation by the same angle.

19 Subsets of the complex plane

The modulus and real and imaginary parts describe curves and regions in the complex plane.

Visualize the following subsets of $\mathbb{C}$. Decide which sets are open, closed, or neither.

19.1 Exercises

Exercise 19.1. $\{z \mid |z - 1| = 1\}$

Exercise 19.2. $\{z \mid |iz - 1| < 1\}$

Exercise 19.3. $\{z \mid |z - i| + |z + i| < 4\}$

Exercise 19.4. $\{z^2 \mid |z - i| = 1\}$

Exercise 19.5. $\{z \mid \Re(e^{i\pi/2}z) > 0\}$

Exercise 19.6. $\{z \mid \Im(z^2) > 0\}$

20 The complex exponential

The functional equation for the exponential and the Cauchy–Riemann equations determine the complex exponential.

In this section, we give some relatively easy exercises to illustrate the important concepts of complex analytic functions.

In this exercise, we derive the complex exponential function. The starting point is the real exponential function, which is the unique function $f(x) = \exp(x)$ that satisfies

$$f(x_1 + x_2) = f(x_1)f(x_2), \quad f(0) = 1.$$

We desire to generalize $\exp(x)$ to the complex plane, so that $\exp(x + 0i) = \exp(x) \in \mathbb{R}$.

To avoid confusion, we call this unknown function $f : \mathbb{C} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$.

20.1 Exercises

Exercise 20.1. Show that $f(x + iy) = \exp(x)f(iy)$. (Thus, we need to determine $f(iy)$.)

Exercise 20.2. We set $f(iy) = A(y) + iB(y)$. Show that

$$A(y) = B'(y), \quad B(y) = -A'(y),$$

and hence that $A''(y) = -A(y)$. Hint: Cauchy–Riemann.

Exercise 20.3. The general solution to the ODE $A'' = -A$ is

$$A(y) = \alpha \cos(y) + \beta \sin(y),$$

where α and β are constants to be determined. Show that $\alpha = 1$ and $\beta = 0$ are the only constants compatible with $f(z)$ being a generalization of the real exponential function.

Exercise 20.4. Conclude that

$$f(x + iy) = e^x(\cos y + i \sin y)$$

Exercise 20.5. Show that $(\exp(z))' = \exp(z)$, using Cauchy–Riemann, and that $\exp(z)$ is everywhere analytic.

Exercise 20.6. Show that the equation

$$\exp(z) = w$$

has infinitely many solutions for any $w \neq 0$.

Exercise 20.7. Show that $\exp(z) \neq 0$.

21 Complex power series

Geometric and exponential series give power-series representations of elementary complex functions.

21.1 Exercises

Exercise 21.1. Consider the geometric series

$$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} z^n = 1 + z + z^2 + \dots \longrightarrow \frac{1}{1-z}.$$

Show that the N th partial sum is

$$\sum_{n=0}^N z^n = \frac{1 - z^{N+1}}{1 - z}.$$

Polynomial long division may be useful.

Exercise 21.2. Find an upper bound for $|z|$ such that the partial sum converges to $1/(1-z)$.

Exercise 21.3. The Taylor series for the exponential function is

$$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n!} z^n.$$

Using the definition of the complex exponential, find the Taylor series for $\cos(x)$ and $\sin(x)$, for $x \in \mathbb{R}$.

Exercise 21.4. Make plots of the partial sums of the sine and cosine Taylor series to verify your result.

Exercise 21.5. Find the Taylor series for the function $f(z) = (e^z - 1)/z$

Exercise 21.6. Find the Taylor series for the function $f(z) = \sin(z)/z$ for $z \neq 0$ and $f(0) = 1$.

22 Singularities and contour integrals

Laurent series classify isolated singularities and determine contour integrals around poles.

22.1 Exercises

22.1.1 Singularities

Exercise 22.1. Consider the function $f(z) = \frac{1}{z(z-1)}$. How many poles does f have, and where are they? What are the order of the poles? Can you write down the Laurent series of f around $z = 0$?

Exercise 22.2. Does the function $f(z) = 1/\sin(z)$ have a pole? Where? What order?

Exercise 22.3. Find the singularities of $f(z) = e^{-1/(z-1)^2}$.

22.1.2 Line integrals

Let

$$f(z) = \frac{1}{z^3 - (2 + i)z^2 + (1 + 2i)z - i}.$$

Exercise 22.4. Let $\Gamma_\epsilon(w)$ be the simple closed curve defined by the counter-clockwise border of the ϵ -ball $B_\epsilon(w)$. Write down a parameterization (a path) for this curve.

Exercise 22.5. Identify the poles $P = \{w_1, w_2, \dots\}$ of $f(z)$ and their order. Hint: A zero of the denominator is $z = i$.

Exercise 22.6. What is the value of

$$\oint_{\Gamma_\epsilon(0)} f(z) \, dz$$

for $\epsilon = 1/2$?

Exercise 22.7. Find the value of the line integrals

$$\oint_{\Gamma_\epsilon(w_i)} f(z) \, dz$$

for $\epsilon = 1/2$. Hint: Do not attempt the integral directly; compute the relevant Laurent coefficient. It can be useful to use the Taylor expansion

$$\frac{1}{a-z} = \frac{1}{a} \frac{1}{1-z/a} = \frac{1}{a} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} (z/a)^n.$$

Part IX

Numerical methods

23 Dual numbers and automatic differentiation

Dual numbers adjoin a nonzero element ε with $\varepsilon^2 = 0$, which encodes first derivatives algebraically.

We now consider the number system called *the dual numbers*, often written $\mathbb{R}(\varepsilon)$. The dual numbers form an algebraic extension of $\mathbb{R}$ with a nonzero element ε such that $\varepsilon^2 = 0$:

$$\mathbb{R}(\varepsilon) = \{x + \varepsilon y \mid x, y \in \mathbb{R}\}.$$

Their construction resembles $\mathbb{C} = \mathbb{R}(i)$, but $i^2 = -1$ while $\varepsilon^2 = 0$. Dual numbers support automatic differentiation.

23.1 Exercises

Exercise 23.1.

1. Compute the multiplication law in terms of real and “dual” parts, i.e., $z_1 z_2 = z = x + \varepsilon y$, and find x and y . Compute the addition law for $z_1 + z_2$.
2. Show that $\mathbb{R}(\varepsilon)$ is not a field.
3. Compute the law for all positive powers of $z = x + \varepsilon y$, and for negative powers when $x \neq 0$.
4. Consider $z = x + \varepsilon$ and evaluate its positive powers, and its negative powers when $x \neq 0$. How is each dual part related to the corresponding real part?
5. Let $p(x)$ be a real polynomial and extend it to dual arguments. Show that

$$p(x + \varepsilon) = p(x) + \varepsilon p'(x).$$

6. Let $q(x)$ be a polynomial in negative powers of x . Show, for $x \neq 0$, that $q(x + \varepsilon) = q(x) + \varepsilon q'(x)$.
7. Let $p(x)$ and $q(x)$ be polynomials, and consider the *rational function* $f(x) = p(x)/q(x)$. Where $q(x) \neq 0$, extend the rational function to $\mathbb{R}(\varepsilon)$ and prove that $f(x + \varepsilon) = f(x) + \varepsilon f'(x)$.

24 Newton's method

Newton's method replaces a nonlinear system by its first-order Taylor approximation at each iteration.

In the next exercise, we derive the Newton–Raphson method for root finding.

Let $f : \Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ be a function of class C^2 . We seek $\mathbf{x} \in \Omega$ such that $f(\mathbf{x}) = 0$.

Assume we have an initial guess $\mathbf{x}_0 \in \Omega$.

24.1 Exercises

Exercise 24.1. Explain why the following polynomial is a good approximation to $f(\mathbf{x})$ near $\mathbf{x}_0$:

$$p(\mathbf{x}) = f(\mathbf{x}_0) + J(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_0), \quad J = Df(\mathbf{x}_0).$$

Exercise 24.2. Newton's method now finds a new guess $\mathbf{x}_1$ by finding the root of the Taylor polynomial, i.e., $p(\mathbf{x}_1) = 0$. Write down a formula for $\mathbf{x}_1$, assuming that the matrix J has an inverse.

Exercise 24.3. Suppose the true solution is $\mathbf{x}_* \in \Omega$, and assume that the error in $\mathbf{x}_0$ is sufficiently small. Find an estimate for the error of $\mathbf{x}_1$. Assuming that the error can be converted to significant digits n , what is the number of significant digits in $\mathbf{x}_1$? Hint: Look at the remainder term.

Exercise 24.4. Suppose successive iterations are performed. How many digits do you have after k iterations?

Exercise 24.5. Make a Python implementation of Newton's method and test it on the following function:

$$f(x, y) = (e^x y^3 - 1, y^2 - \sin(x) - 1).$$

It can be an idea to try and visualize the function. Two roots are:

$$\{(4.38277027, 0.23202192), (0, 1)\}$$

Try different initial guesses $\mathbf{x}_0$, close to the roots and further away. How many iterations do you need to achieve machine precision for your guesses? Can you find more roots?

25 Complex-step differentiation

Complex-step differentiation estimates derivatives without the subtractive cancellation of a centered finite difference.

Let $f(x)$ be a real-valued function, assumed to be analytic near some x , i.e., it agrees with its Taylor series in the vicinity of x .

25.1 Exercises

Exercise 25.1.

1. Explain why there exists a complex analytic function near $x + 0i$ that agrees with f on the real axis.

A classical method for computing a numerical derivative of a C^1 function is the finite difference approximation:

$$f'(x) \approx \delta_h f(x) := \frac{f(x+h) - f(x-h)}{2h}.$$

The error is $\mathcal{O}(h^2)$. In the rest of the exercise, let f be given by

$$f(x) = \exp(x),$$

and we wish to differentiate around $x = 1$.

1. Write a small program that uses standard double precision floating point arithmetic to compute the finite difference derivative for step lengths from the interval $h \in [10^{-9}, 10^{-1}]$.
2. Make a plot of the absolute value of the error in the approximation as function of h . Use log scales.

The *complex step method* utilizes complex analyticity to avoid the cancellation errors seen in the finite difference scheme. It relies on the function in question being implemented/implementable using complex arithmetic.

1. Show that

$$f(x + ih) = f(x) + ihf'(x) - \frac{1}{2}h^2f''(x) - \frac{ih^3}{6}f'''(x) + \mathcal{O}(h^4).$$

2. Solve for $f'(x)$, and show that

$$f'(x) = \Im \frac{f(x + ih)}{h} + \mathcal{O}(h^2).$$

This is the complex step method.

3. In the plot from above, add a plot of the error of the complex step method. Compare.

Part X

Fourier analysis

Part XI

Ordinary differential equations

Part XII

Partial differential equations

Part XIII

Optimization